

HORISTICS

Grammar · Paragrammar · Politics · Quality Of Life · Interpretive News

What grammar is — not what it does

Grammar is the set of fundamental universal concepts of glossology.

¹That sounds simple, but that is what grammar is, not what it does. Most definitions describe what grammar does. Very few say what it is.

²Grammar covers only six fundamental concepts: parts of speech, moods, diatheses, aspects, clauses and syntax. Everything else is paragrammar.

³Take one simple sentence: *We bought fish this morning*. Say it in Danish, Greek, Spanish or any other language, and the words change, the endings change, the word order may change. But the grammar does not.

Parts of speech

⁴*We* is a pronoun, *bought* is a verb, *fish* is a noun, *this* is an adjective and *morning* is a noun. In every language that can say this sentence, the same words do the same jobs.

Mood

⁵The sentence states a fact. It is in the indicative mood, in all languages.

Diathesis

⁶The subject performs the action: we did

The Revealing Power Of Definitions

Enforcing the penalty for breaking the law is not the law itself.

¹²What is justice? Let us define it: **Justice is the prevention of crime**. Once a crime has been committed, no justice can be done, because justice is preventing crime. What follows — arrest, trial, imprisonment — has to do with the penalty for breaking the law, which is not justice. So what is called law enforcement is really penalty enforcement.

¹³This reveals a great deal about the revealing power of definitions, and what it reveals is central to a myriad of misconceptions that derail millions of lives.

¹⁴Consider the phrase we hear on the news every week: the criminal was "brought to justice." He was not. He was brought to penalty. The justice that could have been done was the prevention of his crime, and that moment passed before the crime took place. What remains after the fact is a consequence, not a remedy.

¹⁵Consider the victim. We tell the victim that justice will be done, that the verdict will bring justice. But the harm has already happened, and no sentence undoes it. The victim is promised one thing and given another. Many wait years for a trial expecting relief, and when the sentence comes, they feel strangely empty. They

What grammar is — not what it does

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the buying. The sentence is active, in all languages.

Aspect

⁷ The buying is seen as one complete act. The aspect is synoptic, in all languages.

Clause

⁸ It is a declarative main clause, in all languages.

Syntax

⁹ **We** is the subject, **bought** is the verb, **fish** is the direct object and **this morning** is the adverb, in all languages.

¹⁰ Six concepts, and not one of them changes from language to language. What varies *from language to language* is how each language marks them: its endings, its word order, its spelling, its pronunciation and so on. That is paragrammar. Grammar is what every language shares; paragrammar is how each language dresses it.

¹¹ *In the next edition: the parts of speech, discussed in detail.*

The Revealing Power Of Definitions

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were not wrong to feel it. They were given the wrong word.

¹⁶ Justice is confused with punishment, with revenge, with financial compensation and with the legal. It is none of them. Punishment is the penalty imposed after the crime. Revenge is harm returned for harm. Compensation is money paid for damage already done. The legal is what the law permits or forbids, and it is not uncommon for the legal to be unjust and

for the just to be illegal. Opioids were legally marketed and prescribed on a mass scale, and an epidemic of addiction followed. In many countries, people are penalized for speaking freely. All four come after the crime or stand beside it. Not one of them prevents it, and so not one of them is justice.

¹⁷ Consider the politician. When politicians promise to be tough on crime, they nearly always mean tough on penalty: longer sentences, more prisons, more police after the fact. Each of these acts only after a crime has been committed. By the definition, none of them is justice. A government that spends most of its effort on penalties is not a government that does justice. It is a government that manages the failure of justice.

¹⁸ If justice is the prevention of crime, then justice means eliminating the reasons that lead anyone to commit a crime, so that citizens have no reason to commit crimes in the first place. Every crime has a reason behind it, whether need, ignorance, exclusion or despair. Remove the reason, and the crime has nothing to grow from.

¹⁹ That is primarily the duty of politics, as politics is properly defined. Not the courts, which arrive too late. Not the police, who arrive after the call. Not the prisons, which hold the consequences of a failure that has already happened. Politics is the only institution placed before the crime, where the reasons for it are formed, and so it is the only one that can do justice at all.

²⁰ One definition, stated precisely, moves justice from the courtroom to the classroom, from the prison to the home, from the end of the story to its beginning. That is the revealing power of definitions. A society that confuses penalty with justice will keep building prisons and wondering why crime does not go away. A society that defines justice correctly will ask a different question: not how to punish, but how to prevent.

INTERPRETIVE NEWS

The Use Of Nuclear Weapons Is No Longer Unthinkable

Theodor Herzl was the visionary of Greater Israel

²¹ Theodor Herzl (1860–1904) was an Austro-Hungarian Jewish journalist, writer and political activist who became the central founder of modern political Zionism.

THEODOR HERZL

Born: Budapest, 2 May 1860

Died: Edlach, Austria, 3 July 1904
(buried in Vienna)

Profession: journalist, playwright, writer

Major work: *Der Judenstaat* (The Jewish State), 1896

Political role: organized the First Zionist Congress in Basel in 1897 and became president of the newly established Zionist Organization.

Objective: a publicly and legally secured homeland for the Jewish people.



Theodor Herzl

²² He pursued international diplomatic support for this project, including negotiations with the Ottoman Empire and the British government.

²³ Herzl died decades before the establishment of the State of Israel in 1948, so he did not take part in the creation of the state itself. His writings and political organization nevertheless became foundational to the Zionist movement.

²⁴ To set the tone, let us go back to London in October 1902. On 23 October, according to his own diary, Herzl entered the office of Joseph Chamberlain, Britain's Colonial Secretary, at a quarter past twelve. He came with a request: territory under British control for Jewish colonization. He named three places: Cyprus, El-Arish and the Sinai Peninsula.

²⁵ No transcript of the meeting exists. What survives is Herzl's own account, written in his diary the following day. It is the primary source, and it is revealing precisely because it is his.

²⁶ Herzl explained why he could not simply wait for his negotiations with the Ottoman Sultan, who ruled Palestine. He compared them to buying a carpet: "If you want to buy a carpet, first you must drink half a dozen cups of coffee and smoke a hundred cigarettes; then you discuss family stories, and from time to time you speak again a few words about the carpet. Now I have time to negotiate, but my people has not. They are starving in the Pale. I must bring them immediate help."

²⁷ Chamberlain replied that he could speak with authority only about Cyprus, because El-Arish and Sinai fell under the Foreign Office. On Cyprus, Herzl records his answer:

"Cyprus is inhabited by Greeks and Moslems. I could not crowd them out for the sake of new immigrants. On the contrary, it would be my duty to take their side."

²⁸ Chamberlain then added that if Herzl could point to a place in Britain's possessions where there were no white inhabitants, he would be willing to discuss it.

²⁹ Herzl did not let Cyprus go. He proposed creating a current in favour of Jewish settlement on the island, driven by Jewish capital. In his own words:

"Once we establish the Jewish Eastern Company, with 5 million pounds capital, for settling Sinai and El Arish, the Cypriots will begin to want that golden rain on their island, too. The Moslems will move away, the Greeks will gladly sell their lands at a good price and migrate to Athens or Crete."

³⁰ And Herzl immediately records Chamberlain's reaction: "He seemed to take to the idea."

³¹ The sequence matters. Chamberlain refused to crowd out the Greeks and Muslims of Cyprus. Herzl answered with a plan by which they would leave on their own: the Muslims would move away, the Greeks would sell and emigrate. And by Herzl's account, Chamberlain seemed to take to it. This is not a later interpretation of Herzl's position. It is in his own diary, written during his London negotiations of October 1902.

³² The next day, Chamberlain arranged for Herzl to see the Foreign Secretary, Lord Lansdowne. But he told Herzl to leave Cyprus out of that meeting: "The part of the Plan relating to Cyprus is my business."

³³ The Cyprus option closed there. Britain looked into El-Arish, but that plan failed over the Egyptian government's position and the lack of water. In 1903, Chamberlain offered something else entirely: territory in British East Africa, the so-called Uganda Scheme.

³⁴ Many allege that the October 7, 2023 attack was allowed to happen so that the Netanyahu government could use it to justify the displacement of Palestinians from Gaza. This echoes an aspect of Theodor Herzl's thinking: when discussing Cyprus with Joseph Chamberlain in 1902, Herzl envisaged the departure of the Muslim population and the sale and migration of the Greek population to Athens or Crete.

³⁵ Israel is now pursuing a policy aimed at changing the Iranian regime. Given Iran's size, population, geography, military capabilities and demonstrated resilience, however, it is far from certain that Iran would capitulate through conventional military operations alone. The conflict has already demonstrated Iran's capacity to absorb substantial military pressure while continuing to retaliate.

³⁶ Yet neither Israel nor the United States can easily abandon the goal. Both have invested heavily in regime change, and giving it up would mean a serious loss of face and a heavy psychological blow to both.

³⁷ Meanwhile, there are reports of increasing Israeli involvement with Cyprus, including Israeli investment and security cooperation. If the Israeli government eventually concludes that military pressure will not produce regime change in Iran, a dangerous question arises: would it escalate to the use of tactical nuclear weapons? Such a step would not necessarily guarantee the collapse of the Iranian state and could instead produce an uncontrollable escalation.

³⁸ The consequences could extend far beyond the Middle East. A nuclear attack by Israel could create pressure for other nuclear powers, including Russia and China, to intervene or respond militarily. Whether they would actually use nuclear weapons cannot be predicted, but the possibility would make such an escalation a threat to the entire international community.

³⁹ Donald Trump's threat at the UN General Assembly on 22 September 2026, when he asked whether he should "annihilate the Islamic Republic" if no peace deal is reached, demonstrates how extreme the current rhetoric has become. The possibility of further escalation therefore concerns not merely Israel, Iran or the Middle East, but potentially humanity as a whole.

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